NCCP 00227 · VERSION 9

Your treatment, explained

Advanced gastrointestinal cancers · NCCP 00227 v9 · Document revised 4 November 2026

Your personal plan: this is the standard regimen schedule. Your team confirms your prescribed doses, cycles, treatment changes and appointments in your written plan.

FOLFIRI

14-day cycle

Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending

ACT ON SYMPTOMS, NOT THE CALENDAR

When to get help

Emergency: call 112 / 999

Severe breathing difficulty, collapse, seizure or severe chest pain: call emergency services. Do not wait for an online answer.

Contact your oncology service immediately

Temperature 37.5°C or higher, 36°C or lower, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell — even with a normal temperature. Contact promptly for new chest symptoms, severe or persistent diarrhoea, reduced urine, inability to drink, severe abdominal pain or a line/pump problem.

Follow the urgent contact instructions from your treating hospital. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment. Outside clinic hours, use your instructed out-of-hours pathway or the emergency department.

This page does not diagnose symptoms or decide whether it is safe to stay at home. You do not need to know which medicine caused a symptom before calling.

Open your CUH contact / treatment card

Sources: nccp · hse

YOUR COMPLETE REFERENCE

Read what you need, when you need it.

Start with the overview, explore the cycle, or go straight to a question. Urgent advice is always available.

- How each drug works
- Your treatment plan
- Your 14-day timeline
- Baseline and cycle-specific checks
- Whole treatment, scans and checks
- Your port and treatment pump
- Tablets, visits and practical planning
- Your treatment aim and review plan
- Bowel symptoms: act early
- Tests and preparation
- Eating, activity and daily life
- Medicines and supportive care
- Prepare for the next conversation
- Supportive medicines
- Understanding the evidence
- Questions to ask

Sources

UNDERSTAND YOUR TREATMENT

Your medicines and what they do

FOLFIRI combines irinotecan, folinic acid and fluorouracil. NCCP 00227 covers advanced colorectal cancer, metastatic oesophageal cancer and second-line advanced pancreatic cancer. Your team confirms your indication and treatment aim.

TOPOISOMERASE I CHEMOTHERAPY

Irinotecan

Campto



Interrupts DNA copying

The body converts irinotecan into SN-38. This traps an enzyme called topoisomerase I while DNA is being copied, causing damage that can stop cancer cells dividing. Normal bowel and blood-forming cells can also be affected.

Irinotecan becomes SN-38 → DNA-repair enzyme is trapped → Dividing cells are damaged

What to watch for

Tell the nurse immediately about cramps, sweating or diarrhoea during the infusion. Diarrhoea starting later needs the separate written treatment and contact plan.

Sources: nccp · patient

CHEMOTHERAPY MODULATOR

Folinic acid

Calcium leucovorin



Strengthens fluorouracil action

Folinic acid helps fluorouracil remain bound to an enzyme needed to make DNA. In this regimen it increases fluorouracil activity and can also increase its unwanted effects. It is not a vitamin supplement to start yourself.

Folinic acid → Stronger enzyme binding → Fluorouracil effect increases

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What to watch for

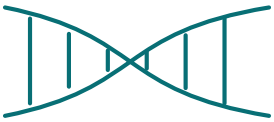
The combined treatment can increase mouth soreness and diarrhoea. Report these promptly. Rare allergic reactions can occur.

Sources: nccp · patient

CHEMOTHERAPY

Fluorouracil

5-FU



Disrupts cell building blocks

Fluorouracil interferes with the production and use of DNA and RNA, the instructions cells need to grow. The infusion extends exposure over approximately two days.

Drug enters cell → DNA / RNA disrupted → Growth slows

What to watch for

Diarrhoea, mouth sores and skin soreness may become serious. Chest pain during the pump infusion needs emergency assessment. Unexpected severe early toxicity can occur even after DPD testing.

Sources: nccp · patient

The drawings are simplified explanations of drug action, not anatomical pictures or a prediction of response.

Explore your existing anatomy and side-effect map

THE BIGGER TREATMENT PLAN

Your treatment plan

DAY WARD → HOME PUMP → REVIEW

14-day treatment cycle

D1 D2 D3 D14

Day 1: irinotecan, folinic acid and fluorouracil, then a 46-hour fluorouracil pump. A cycle lasts 14 days; your team confirms the next treatment.

Treatment is reviewed against benefit, side effects and your priorities. Reductions, breaks or a maintenance plan are individual decisions, not an automatic change after a set number of cycles.

Sources: nccp

BASELINE → TREATMENT → FOLLOW-UP

Checks across the whole treatment course

The columns show the order of care, not equal lengths of time. Confirm who books each check, who reviews it and whom to call if it is missing.

Check	Before starting	Each treatment cycle	Between doses	Decision / response review	Completion / change
Blood count / kidneys / liver	Baseline bloods; DPD before fluoropyrimidine	Repeat before each cycle	Earlier tests if unwell, dehydrated or toxicity develops	Results and recovery guide any delay or dose change	Follow unresolved abnormalities
Symptoms and function	Document existing symptoms and usual activity	Review worst symptoms since the last treatment	Use urgent contacts; do not wait for the next visit	Balance benefit, side effects and priorities	Agree recovery care and ongoing support
Heart checks	Review cardiac history; ECG when cardiac function is compromised or clinical findings warrant it. No automatic serial echocardiogram schedule is specified for this regimen.	Ask about new chest pain or breathlessness	Chest pain needs urgent assessment	Repeat heart tests if clinically indicated	Follow any heart problem; no fixed echo series
Response / scans	Confirm cancer setting, disease assessment and intended duration	Review clinical benefit and symptoms	New symptoms may bring review forward	Consultant response review after two cycles; NCCP says stop if no response	Agree follow-up, completion or another treatment

The team arranges and reviews tests. This guide shows expected timing; it does not record completed appointments. NCCP 00227 v9 · official regimen

THE WHOLE TREATMENT JOURNEY

FOLFIRI: treatment and checks

Advanced gastrointestinal cancers

Day 1: irinotecan, folinic acid and fluorouracil, then a 46-hour fluorouracil pump. A cycle lasts 14 days; your team confirms the next treatment.

Read from left to right. Columns show stages, not equal lengths of time. This is a general plan: no dates or personal information are needed. Your team confirms which steps apply and arranges appointments.

On a small screen, swipe the map sideways. The checks below give the same timing in words.

Treatment, tests and reviews across the course

Care / check	Before starting	Each treatment cycle	Between doses	Decision / response review	Completion / change
Blood count / kidneys / liver NCCP 00227	Baseline bloods; DPD before fluoropyrimidine	Repeat before each cycle	Earlier tests if unwell, dehydrated or toxicity develops	Results and recovery guide any delay or dose change	Follow unresolved abnormalities
Symptoms and function NCCP 00227	Document existing symptoms and usual activity	Review worst symptoms since the last treatment	Use urgent contacts; do not wait for the next visit	Balance benefit, side effects and priorities	Agree recovery care and ongoing support
Heart checks NCCP 00227	Review cardiac history; ECG when cardiac function is compromised or clinical findings warrant it. No automatic serial echocardiogram schedule is specified for this regimen.	Ask about new chest pain or breathlessness	Chest pain needs urgent assessment	Repeat heart tests if clinically indicated	Follow any heart problem; no fixed echo series
Response / scans NCCP 00227	Confirm cancer setting, disease assessment and intended duration	Review clinical benefit and symptoms	New symptoms may bring review forward	Consultant response review after two cycles; NCCP says stop if no response	Agree follow-up, completion or another treatment

What each check is for

1

Confirm your personal plan

Before starting

FOLFIRI combines irinotecan, folinic acid and fluorouracil. NCCP 00227 covers advanced colorectal cancer, metastatic oesophageal cancer and second-line advanced pancreatic cancer. Your team confirms your indication and treatment aim.

Ask / act: Agree medicines, treatment days, duration and monitoring.

Sources: NCCP 00227

At the next review, ask

- Which treatment phase am I in, and what happens next?
- Which test is expected next, who arranges it, and who explains the result?
- Who should I contact if an expected appointment has not arrived?

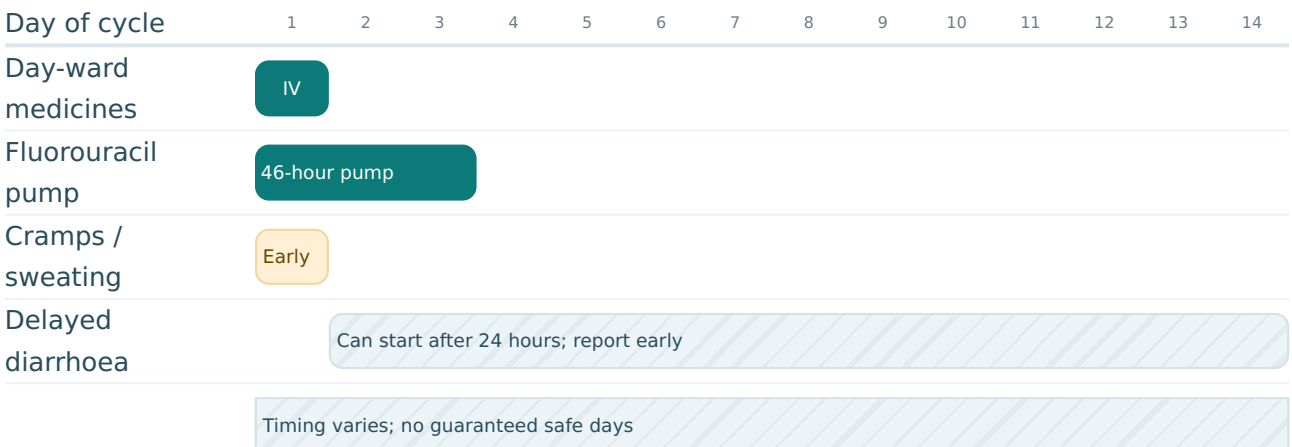
This map does not show whether a test has been ordered, booked or completed. Do not wait for a scheduled test if you develop new symptoms.

Sources checked 2026-11-04 · Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending · SACTCheck v0.84.32

Day 1 → Day 14: a general pattern

This is a visual orientation, not a prediction of your personal cycle. It shows when some effects often emerge and which effects are **not** tied to a particular day.

Day 1: irinotecan, folinic acid and fluorouracil, then a 46-hour fluorouracil pump. A cycle lasts 14 days; your team confirms the next treatment.



Blood counts / infection	
Mouth / bowel / energy	Record symptoms throughout

Day ward and home pump: Day 1 infusions lead into a 46-hour pump. The team confirms the disconnection appointment.

Two types of diarrhoea: Cramps and sweating during infusion need immediate nursing attention. Later diarrhoea needs your written home plan and early contact.

No safe window: Fever or sudden illness needs prompt action on any day, including after pump removal.

Between visits: Bowel symptoms, mouth soreness and fatigue can overlap. Describe their effect on eating, drinking and daily tasks.

Why these bands stay broad: Bars show planned treatment and possible symptom patterns, not measured risk. Side effects can overlap and persist. Band length does not show likelihood or severity, and the chart cannot tell you whether it is safe to receive treatment. NCCP 00227 v9 · official regimen ↗ · eviQ: patient explanation (NCCP defines your regimen schedule) ↗

There are no guaranteed “safe days”. Act on fever, sudden illness or a new serious symptom whenever it occurs. Do not wait for the next appointment.

Read the whole cycle as text

Day 1: Infusion and pump connection

The team reviews symptoms, blood results and your treatment plan. Day-ward infusions are followed by connection of the fluorouracil pump. Before leaving, confirm the pump-care instructions, disconnection appointment and contact number.

Day 2–3: The pump is delivering treatment

The pump runs for approximately 46 hours from connection. Keep it and the line secure and dry as taught. The team confirms the actual disconnection appointment. Call for a leaking, disconnected or unexpectedly stopped pump. Do not reconnect, alter settings or disconnect it yourself unless specifically trained and instructed.

Day 4–7: After disconnection

Delayed diarrhoea can begin after the first 24 hours and may continue after the pump is removed. Use the written plan and contact the team early. Mouth soreness, nausea and tiredness can overlap. Report poor intake, persistent diarrhoea or mouth pain early. Chest pain or major breathing difficulty requires emergency help.

Day 8–14: Between visits and the next review

Blood counts can fall between visits. Tell the team about bowel symptoms, mouth pain and how you are managing daily activities. Treatment proceeds only after review. Bring the symptom passport and check the next appointment. Day 1 usually repeats 14 days after this cycle started, only if confirmed.

YOUR TREATMENT, STEP BY STEP

Your port and treatment pump

From preparing the line to coming home after disconnection. Your team arranges the appointments and shows you what to do.



1 · Before treatment

Choose and prepare the line

The team explains whether a port or PICC suits your treatment. You receive instructions for the insertion appointment.



2 · Insertion and recovery

A separate appointment may be needed

For a port, numbing medicine is used and a small device is placed under the skin. Ask about sedation, transport and wound care.



3 · Day 1

The nurse connects your pump

After the day-ward medicines, the nurse checks and connects the fluorouracil pump. Ask for a demonstration before leaving.

4 · At home

Treatment continues for about 46 hours

Carry the pump as shown. Keep the dressing dry and protect the line from pulling, heat and damage.

5 · As arranged

Return for disconnection

A trained professional checks the infusion, disconnects the pump and cares for the line. The appointment is based on connection time.

6 · Between cycles

The access device usually stays

A port needle can be removed while the port stays under the skin. A PICC remains in the arm with ongoing dressing and line care.

Port or PICC: what is the difference?

A port is a small chamber beneath the skin, usually on the chest, attached to a tube ending in a large vein. A special needle goes through the skin into the port when it is used. A PICC enters a vein in the upper arm; a short section remains outside under a dressing. Both can deliver a home infusion. Your team helps choose the device and teaches its care.

Before insertion and during recovery

Tell the team about allergies, blood thinners, infections and any other cancer medicines. Follow the instructions about eating, drinking and transport; do not stop medicines yourself. Port placement uses local anaesthetic, sometimes with sedation or general anaesthetic. The team explains the procedure and risks, including infection, bleeding, clots and insertion complications. Ask how to manage discomfort, protect the wound and resume activity. Report increasing pain, redness, swelling, discharge or fever.

Connection: what the nurse does

The nurse checks the line and treatment, secures the connection and dressing, and starts the pump. Before leaving, you should have the disconnection location and time, contact numbers including out of hours, and the written spill instructions. Ask to be shown what normal pump progress looks like. You do not need to calculate a rate.

Carrying it, sleeping and washing

Use the supplied carrier and the position recommended for your pump. Keep tubing free from pulling and kinks. Ask how to place the pump safely for sleep and how to protect the line and dressing when washing. Do not immerse it or swim. Avoid direct heat and cold. An elastomeric pump has a balloon that shrinks slowly and may have no alarm; an electronic pump has different instructions. Follow the instructions for the device you actually receive.

Disconnection is not port removal

Keep the appointment even if the pump looks empty, unless the team changes the plan. Staff check the pump and line and arrange safe disposal. After flushing and other line care as required, the port needle may be removed and a small dressing applied. The implanted port stays in place until a separate removal procedure is arranged. A PICC remains in place and needs scheduled dressing and flushing care.

Leakage, disconnection or unexpected pump progress

Call the team immediately if the pump leaks, is damaged, finishes unexpectedly early, appears not to run, or the line disconnects. Follow the emergency or spill steps you have been specifically taught, including use of a clamp if instructed. Do not reconnect, change settings or disconnect the pump yourself. Keep other people away from leaked medicine. If medicine touches skin, rinse it off and wash with soap and water, then seek advice.

Pain, swelling or feeling unwell

Contact oncology immediately for pain or swelling around the line, a wet/loose dressing, redness, fever, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell. A painful swollen arm or neck needs urgent advice. Severe chest pain, major breathing difficulty or collapse: call 112 / 999. Do not wait for pump disconnection or the next clinic visit.

The drawings show general steps, not instructions for inserting or accessing a line. Your hospital confirms its own arrangements and the care instructions for your device.

Open the complete port and pump guide · **Printable port and pump guide**

Sources: eviQ: port · eviQ: PICC · eviQ: pump. Reviewed against these sources 16 October 2026; local nursing and patient review pending.

PRACTICAL TREATMENT GUIDE

Practical treatment planning

Agree the arrangements with your oncology team.



STEP 1

Before the first treatment

Confirm the aim, likely course length, blood-test arrangements and a working urgent contact number. DPD testing is required before starting the fluoropyrimidine unless already completed.



STEP 2

Line and pump arrangements

Confirm venous access, the 46-hour fluorouracil pump and disconnection arrangements before leaving. Know whom to contact for leakage, an alarm, line pain or a pump that finishes unexpectedly.



STEP 3

If treatment is delayed

Ask the unit to confirm the new treatment and blood-test dates. Re-anchor supportive medicines to the treatment actually given; do not take an extra or catch-up anticancer dose yourself.



STEP 4

Getting help between visits

Follow your oncology unit’s urgent advice for fever, infection, severe diarrhoea, chest pain or difficulty breathing. Bring your treatment card and current medicines list.

Open practical treatment guide · **Printable practical guide**

Sources: NCCP 00227 v9 · official regimen. Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending.

MAKE THE PLAN PRACTICAL

Support around the medicines

1 Nausea prevention and rescue

Take the prescribed prevention medicines at the planned times and keep rescue treatment available. Tell the team if nausea or constipation is not controlled; do not duplicate steroid or anti-sickness medicines.

2 Bowel symptoms

Irinotecan can cause immediate cramps or sweating during the infusion and delayed diarrhoea afterwards. These need different treatments. Ask for the written rescue and urgent-contact plan before starting.

3 Counts and recovery

White-cell growth-factor injections are prescribed according to individual risk and previous complications. They are not automatically required for every patient or every cycle.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 01

Your treatment aim and review plan

Ask what treatment is intended to achieve for you.

Confirm the cancer setting

FOLFIRI combines irinotecan, folinic acid and fluorouracil. NCCP 00227 covers advanced colorectal cancer, metastatic oesophageal cancer and second-line advanced pancreatic cancer. Your team confirms your indication and treatment aim.

Sources: nccp · patient

Review rather than a fixed promise

Ask when scans and clinical review will assess benefit. Treatment may be adjusted if it is not helping or side effects outweigh benefit. A cycle delay is not itself proof that treatment has stopped working.

Sources: nccp · patient

Your priorities matter

Discuss symptoms you want to improve, daily activities, work, caring responsibilities and time at home. The team can explain alternatives and how they compare in your situation.

Sources: nccp · patient

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 02

Bowel symptoms: act early

Keep the written plan with your medicines.

During the infusion

With irinotecan, sudden cramps, sweating, a runny nose or diarrhoea can occur during or soon after treatment. Tell the nurse immediately; this needs a different approach from delayed diarrhoea.

Sources: nccp · patient

At home

Record changes from your usual bowel pattern or stoma output. Follow your prescribed diarrhoea plan and contact oncology if symptoms persist or you cannot replace lost fluids. Do not wait for the next scheduled visit.

Sources: nccp · patient

Get urgent advice

Fever, severe pain, blood in stools, dizziness, reduced urine or inability to drink alongside diarrhoea needs urgent assessment. Severe abdominal pain must not be assumed to be an ordinary treatment effect.

Sources: nccp · patient

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 03

Tests and preparation

Checks support safe treatment even when you feel well.

Blood tests and symptoms

The team reviews blood counts, kidney and liver function and symptoms before another cycle. Missing information is not assumed to be normal.

Sources: nccp · patient

DPD and fluorouracil

DPD helps the body break down fluorouracil. Deficiency can cause severe toxicity. Testing guides the plan but cannot exclude all serious reactions; unexpectedly severe early diarrhoea, mouth sores or illness needs immediate review.

Sources: nccp · patient

Additional checks

Tell the team about liver disease, previous severe diarrhoea, heart problems and all medicines. Irinotecan handling can differ between people; any additional testing is decided by your team.

Sources: nccp · patient

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 04

Eating, activity and daily life

Choose manageable steps and ask for help early.

Food and fluids

Take prescribed anti-sickness medicines. Small regular meals may be easier when appetite is low. Tell the team if vomiting, mouth soreness or diarrhoea prevents enough intake; follow any fluid restriction you have.

Sources: hse · patient

Activity and rest

Short, comfortable activity and planned rests can help you organise the day. Avoid activity that pulls the line or risks damaging the pump. Ask about work, driving and travel around your own treatment and symptoms.

Sources: hse · patient · pump

Sex, fertility and pregnancy

Discuss fertility preservation before treatment where relevant. Ask about contraception, pregnancy, breastfeeding and precautions around sex during treatment; the required precautions depend on the medicines.

Sources: nccp · patient

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 05

Medicines and supportive care

Bring a complete list, including supplements.

Before adding medicines

Check new prescriptions, over-the-counter products and supplements with the oncology pharmacist. Do not independently stop regular medicines such as anticoagulants before a procedure.

Sources: nccp · patient

Supportive prescriptions

Keep anti-sickness medicines and the bowel-symptom plan accessible. If growth-factor injections are prescribed, confirm when they are due in relation to the pump; do not infer timing from the graph.

Sources: nccp · patient

Treatment changes

Ask which medicine is being delayed, reduced or stopped and why. Each medicine can change separately; record the agreed plan in your own treatment documents.

Sources: nccp · patient

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 06

Prepare for the next conversation

You do not have to remember everything.

Bring your questions

Use the passport to note symptoms and their effect on eating, drinking, sleep and everyday tasks. You do not need to work out which medicine caused them.

Sources: nccp · patient

Ask for practical support

Ask for a written appointment and contact plan, an interpreter if needed, and help for a family member or carer learning the pump instructions.

Sources: nccp · patient

Tell us what was unclear

Ask the nurse to demonstrate the pump and line, then explain back when and how you would seek help. More explanation is appropriate whenever you need it.

Sources: nccp · patient

Understanding the evidence

Ask which evidence matches your cancer, treatment aim and medicines.

A trial in metastatic colorectal cancer found similar overall results when FOLFIRI and FOLFOX6 were used in different sequences. Their side effects differed. This does not establish the best sequence for everyone or quantify benefit in oesophageal or pancreatic cancer.

Sources: trial

PREPARE FOR THE CONVERSATION

Questions worth asking

Does having more side effects mean treatment is working?

No. Side effects do not reliably show whether the cancer is responding. Report them so they can be treated. Your team assesses benefit using the tests and review plan appropriate to your cancer.

Why might a dose be delayed or reduced?

Your team may allow recovery, investigate a symptom or reduce the chance of lasting harm. Ask which drug changes, why, and when review is planned. A delay does not itself mean treatment has failed.

What should I say when calling?

Give the regimen name, last treatment date, symptoms and when they started. Explain whether you can eat, drink, pass urine and manage usual activities. Give your temperature if available, but do not delay calling to collect details.

What belongs in the consent conversation?

The individual aim and likely benefit, uncertainty, reasonable alternatives including not proceeding, common and serious risks, lasting effects, fertility and practical concerns. You can ask for an interpreter, more time or another explanation and can reconsider your decision.

How many cycles should I use this passport for?

The passport provides reusable recording pages, not a prescribed course length. Your oncology team sets the duration and can provide extra pages.

Will I need a port or a PICC?

The team chooses the most suitable access device with you. A port is under the skin; a PICC enters through the upper arm and has an external section. Both require specific care, and the pump can be used with either.

Does disconnecting the pump remove my port?

No. At the arranged visit the pump is disconnected and the line cared for. A port needle may be removed, but the implanted port stays under the skin until a separate removal procedure is arranged.

What if the pump finishes early or still looks full?

Contact the team for advice. Do not change delivery settings or disconnect or reconnect it yourself. Follow only the specific emergency steps you have been taught.

Is delayed diarrhoea the same as cramps during infusion?

No. Irinotecan can cause an early reaction with cramps, sweating or diarrhoea, and a later diarrhoea problem. Tell the nurse about early symptoms and follow the separate written plan at home.

> **Try explaining the plan back:** Can you explain which medicines you are receiving, the schedule, the contact plan and the symptoms that need prompt help?

SOURCE TRANSPARENCY

Where this information comes from

Regimen schedule: NCCP 00227 v9. Medicine explanations and safety information: sources below. The timeline is an educational illustration, not a measured risk curve or an individual prediction.

- NCCP 00227 v9 · official regimen
- eviQ: patient explanation (NCCP defines your regimen schedule)
- HSE: chemotherapy side effects and urgent advice
- NCI: nausea and vomiting
- eviQ: treatment through an implanted port
- eviQ: treatment through a PICC
- eviQ: elastomeric infusion pump care
- GERCOR sequencing study (2004)

SACTCheck · Developed by Dr Paul O'Brien · Sources checked 2026-11-04.
This information supports your treatment discussion. Your oncology team confirms your personal treatment and urgent-care plan.

Written source addresses

https://healthservice.hse.ie/documents/6563/227_v9_FOLFIRI.pdf

https://www.eviq.org.au/medical-oncology/upper-gastrointestinal/gastric-and-oesophageal-metastatic/4043-advanced-or-metastatic-folfiri-modified-fl/patient-information

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